



The Power Elite. by C. Wright Mills

Review by: A. T. Wright

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disappointed at the failure to list the Signal Corps Museum at Fort Monmouth, New Jersey; and some persons will regret the omission of a brief description of the historical program and organization of the Department of the Army and of a list of all the governing directives. Unfortunately, as in many government publications, this one omits the names of contributors.

In spite of the general excellence of this work, a major exception must be taken to the explanation in the preface that "a military historian is one who is well-informed in military history and in subjects related to the military profession. Therefore, *any professionally qualified officer is a military historian*. In a narrower sense, a military historian is a writer or chronicler of military activities." Professional military historians, both in and out of uniform, will question the validity of the major premise and will resent the implication that their years of training in research and writing count for little. The cause of history is not well served by this presumptuous and ill-considered definition which heeds not the old admonition about the shoemaker and his last.

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The Power Elite, by C. Wright Mills. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1956. Pp. 423. \$6.00.)

The author sets out to prove that there is, indeed, a "peck-order" in the hierarchies controlling the government of the United States today. He proceeds to ferret out these chameleons in the corporate bodies where, he is convinced, they are nourished and from which they emerge at strategic intervals to control or influence the vital decision-making bodies of our present government.

The author's thesis is that there are three dominant hierarchies in our nation's economic, military, and political structures. At the pinnacle of each of the three enlarged and centralized domains, there have arisen those higher, "basically irresponsible," circles which make up the corresponding "power" elites. At the top of the economy, among the corporate rich, there are the chief executives; at the top of the political order, the members of the political directorate; at the top of the military establishment, the elite of soldier-statesmen clustered in and around the Joint Chiefs of Staff and the upper echelon. The power that these few men exercise is not of themselves, their wealth, or knowledge. It derives rather from

their position in the great institutions. And if they are taken away from these resources then they would be powerless and poor and uncelebrated.

The chapters on "The Warlords," and "The Military Ascendancy" are most pertinent. In the latter, he points out that, as a result of our "permanent war economy," the military has invaded every field in the civilian economy: political, economic, educational, scientific. He feels that this is due to civilian default rather than military usurpation. All this has led to the party politician and the legislative branches being relegated to the "middle level" of national power, the Congress having abdicated to the Executive Branch, which now dictates policy through the "political outsiders" drawn from the world of big business. Although the author does not predict what the final results will be from this change in the "peck-order," it is clear that tranquillity in the flock will not be restored until the "peck-order" is again clearly defined.

Although tedious in some parts, the book is stimulating, thought-provoking, and well worth reading by students of the history of military institutions.

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Air War Against Germany and Italy, 1939-1943 [Australia in the War of 1939-1945, Volume III of Series 3 (Air)], by John Herington. (Canberra: Australian War Memorial, 1954. New York, 1955. Pp. 731. 25s.).

The projected twenty-two volume history of *Australia in the War of 1939-1945* is divided into five series dealing with army, navy, air, civil and medical services. This massive volume under consideration is the first of the four projected Royal Australian Air Force volumes to appear. As such, it recommends to the serious student of World War II the genuine contribution and usefulness of the Australian historical efforts. This particular volume should be regarded as a monument to the historical genius of its author who faced a very difficult task indeed.

War circumstances largely dictated the integration of Dominion contingents into a vast Commonwealth air force. Almost every Royal Air Force squadron contained Australian airmen. In 1939 there was but one Australian squadron in England and some 400 Australians were scattered